

THE DEFENSIBLE NUMBER

The price your boss approves first time.

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What the customer buys for USD 9.99: the method for walking into the boss's office with a number that survives questioning. The one-page Defense Sheet format, the four prompts that build it, and the answers ready before the questions come — from the boss or the customer.

The core idea

A number without reasoning is an opinion. Bosses re-check opinions — every cent, every time, sometimes redoing your whole costing at 9 PM. Bosses *approve* reasoning.

The defensible number is three things stapled together: **the number, the basis, and the boundaries.** Where every figure came from. What was assumed. How far it can move before it breaks. Put those on one page and the boss's job changes from "check everything" to "approve the method" — and approval takes minutes, not days.

You're not selling the boss a price.

You're selling the boss certainty that the price is safe.

PART 1 — BEFORE YOU COST ANYTHING: THE FOUR NO-BID

CHECKS

The fastest way to lose the boss's trust is spending two days costing a job the company should never touch. Run these four checks on every enquiry — two minutes — and when one fails, going to the boss with "I recommend we decline, here's why" is itself a defensible number. Sometimes the most professional answer is a fast, reasoned no.

1. **Can we actually make it?** Process, tolerance, certification — or would we be subcontracting the hard part?
2. **Does it fit our nature?** (Module 01) A one-off custom job in a volume shop, or volume work in a job shop, usually ends badly
3. **Do we have the capacity window** they need — honestly?
4. **Any clause that bites?** Open-ended quality terms, "or equivalent" materials, penalty clauses, unrealistic dates

PART 2 — THE DEFENSE SHEET (THE ARTIFACT)

One page that travels WITH your number to the boss. Five blocks:

Block	What it shows	The boss question it kills
1. The enquiry, verified	What the customer actually asked for — quantities, specs, dates — plus the ambiguities you already clarified	"Did you read the whole RFQ properly?"
2. The cost basis	Which rates and assumptions were used, and where each came from	"Where did this figure come from?"
3. The market basis	What this customer paid before · our last 3 outcomes with them · any known target price	"Are we too high? Too low?"

4. The options	Price at each quantity tier, with the floor marked — so "what if they take 2,000?" is already answered	"And if the volume changes?"
5. The risks + your recommendation	What could bite, what you propose, in one sentence	"So what do you want me to do?"

Why this works on a real SEA boss: he doesn't re-check every cent because he enjoys it — he does it because he's the one who answers for a bad number, and your Excel gives him nothing to hold onto. The Defense Sheet gives him handles. After three or four of these, something changes: he stops checking your arithmetic and starts asking your opinion. That's the promotion path hiding inside a piece of paper.

PART 3 — THE FOUR PROMPTS (AI ASSEMBLES, YOU DECIDE)

PROMPT 1 — The Enquiry Reader (Block 1, and your first impression)

You are a careful estimator's assistant in a manufacturing office. I will paste a customer enquiry. Extract what I need before anyone starts costing:

ENQUIRY: [paste email/RFQ text]

GIVE ME:

1. Line items: parts, quantities (every tier mentioned), dates
2. Materials, tolerances, treatments, certifications demanded
3. ⚠️ **AMBIGUITIES** — every vague line I should clarify BEFORE costing (missing revision, unspecified finish, contradictions). Write the clarification questions for me, polite and short, ready to send.
4. **RED FLAGS** — clauses that bite later: open-ended quality terms, "or equivalent" materials, penalties, dates that don't fit normal lead times

RULES: Extract only what is written. Never assume a spec that isn't there.

The clarification email is the most important output – asking sharp questions early makes my office look thorough, not slow.

PROMPT 2 – The Cost Basis Builder (Block 2 – a draft for YOUR judgment)

You are helping me build the cost basis for a manufacturing proposal. I give you the inputs; you calculate transparently and list every assumption so my boss can see the reasoning.

INPUTS: [part description / process steps or cycle time if known / material grade + my price per kg / our machine rate per hour / overhead rate / target margin %]

GIVE ME:

1. Material cost per piece – blank size, weight, scrap factor (state which % and why), all math shown
2. Processing cost per piece – time × rate, with your reasoning; give RANGES where uncertain and mark anything that needs a human estimate from the floor
3. The floor price at my margin, per quantity tier: [tiers]
4. ASSUMPTIONS LIST – every assumption made, one line each, so nothing is hidden inside a cell

RULES: This is a DRAFT basis for my judgment, not an answer. Where you are unsure, say so loudly – an honest range beats a confident guess. Never invent a rate I did not give you.

PROMPT 3 – The Defense Builder (the heart of the module)

You are my preparation partner before I take a number to my boss. Build my one-page Defense Sheet, then interrogate it like the boss will.

MY MATERIAL: [paste Prompt 1 output, Prompt 2 output, and what I know about this customer: past prices, last 3 quote outcomes, any target price, payment behaviour]

MY RECOMMENDED PRICE: [price per tier]

STEP 1 – Assemble the Defense Sheet, five blocks:

1. The enquiry, verified (with clarifications already resolved)
2. The cost basis (rates, assumptions, sources – one line each)
3. The market basis (what they paid, our history, their target)
4. The options (price per quantity tier, floor marked)
5. Risks + my one-sentence recommendation

STEP 2 – Now be my boss. Ask me the THREE hardest questions he will ask about this number – and draft my answers from the sheet. Typical bosses ask: "Why not cheaper to win it?" / "What did they pay last time?" / "What if they double the quantity?" – but choose the three sharpest for THIS case.

STEP 3 – Tell me the weakest point in my sheet – the one thing I should fix or find out before the meeting, not during it.

PROMPT 4 – The Pushback Partner (after the customer answers)

The customer has pushed back on our proposal. Help me respond without giving away the floor, and without promising anything that is my boss's call.

SITUATION: [what the customer said – "too expensive" / "competitor is 15% lower" / "we need it at X" / "can you do 2,000 instead"]

MY SHEET: [paste the Defense Sheet from Prompt 3]

GIVE ME:

1. What their pushback most likely means (price test? real budget limit? volume genuine?) – and what to ask to find out
2. TWO response drafts, professional Asian B2B tone: one that holds price and sells value, one that trades something FOR something (volume, lead time, payment terms – never a naked discount)
3. THE ESCALATION LINE: exactly where my authority should end here and what to bring to my boss – with the one-line summary I'd give him

RULES: Never offer a price below the floor on my sheet. Never apologise for the price. Escalating with a clear recommendation is strength, not weakness.

PART 4 — WORKED EXAMPLE: TUESDAY, 4:50 PM

The old way: enquiry arrives Monday. You cost it for two days between other work. Boss looks at your Excel Thursday, questions three cells, changes your margin, asks what they paid last year — you don't know — and redoes half of it Friday night. Quote goes out late. Everyone slightly annoyed, mostly at you.

With the module: Monday morning, Prompt 1 reads the enquiry and drafts two clarification questions — customer answers by noon, and your office looked sharp doing it. Prompt 2 builds the cost basis; you correct one cycle-time with a quick walk to the floor. Prompt 3 assembles the Defense Sheet and grills you with the three questions the boss will ask — you fix the weak point it found (you didn't know last year's price; a colleague did). Tuesday 4:50 PM you put ONE PAGE on the boss's desk. He reads it top to bottom, asks one question — the answer is in Block 4 — and signs.